

## Why Crows are Black

The Sun, while going on his daily rounds, saw a princess and fell in love with her. Whenever he could slip away from the **heavens**, he would take human form and go down to the princess to spend some time with her. The princess too became quite **fond of** him and would wait for him to come.

One day the Sun decided to send her a **blood-red ruby** as a **token** of his love for her. He put the gem in a **silken bag**, and calling a crow that was flying past, asked the bird to deliver the gem to his **beloved**. Crows had milky white feathers in those days and it was considered **auspicious** if a crow came anywhere near you. So the Sun was **pleased** that he had found a crow to deliver the gem.



As the crow **sped through** the sky with the silken bag, the **aroma** of food reached its **nostrils**. Looking down, it saw that a wedding **feast** was in progress, and immediately it was distracted from its mission. Food was one thing it could never **resist**!

**Alighting** on a tree nearby, it hung the bag on a **twig** and went off to find some food.

While the crow was feasting, a merchant **passing by** saw the bag on the tree, and **knocked it down** with a pole.

When he opened the bag and saw its contents, he almost **swooned** in joy. Quickly pocketing the ruby, he filled the bag with dry cow dung that was lying there, and then **deftly** returned the bag to the branch.

It was all done so quickly that the crow missed all the action. After having its fill, it flew up to the tree, and picking up the bag, took it to the person it was **intended for**. The princess was in the garden. When the crow gave her the bag, she took it **eagerly**, knowing that it was from the Sun. But when she saw its contents, she **reeled** back in shock and anger.

Believing that it was the Sun's way of telling her that he did not care for her, she flung the bag away, rushed to her palace, and never came out again.

When the Sun learnt of what had happened, he was **furious**. So great was his anger that when he turned his **scorching gaze** on the crow, its feathers were burned black.

Its feathers have been black ever since.

The story goes on to tell us that the ruby did not stay with the man who stole it. It fell out of his pocket and rolled into a deep **pit**.

Men have been trying to **dig** it **out** ever since. Many precious stones have been found in the process, making Burma (now Myanmar) one of the richest sources of rubies and **sapphires**, but the ruby that the Sun sent to the princess has yet to be found.

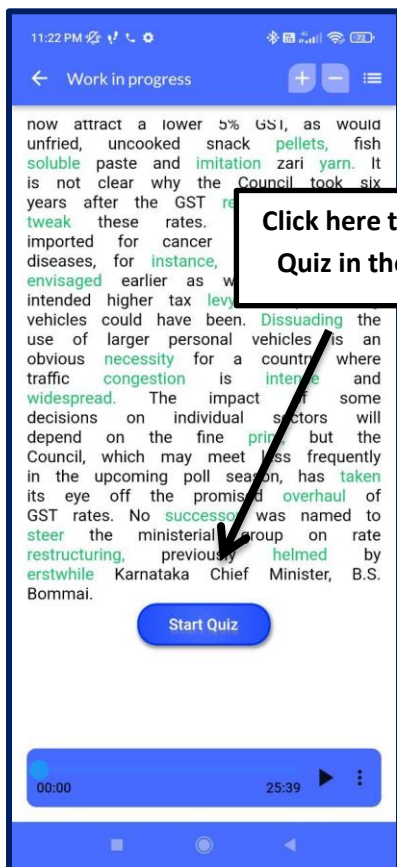
@mocks\_wallah

### Vocabulary

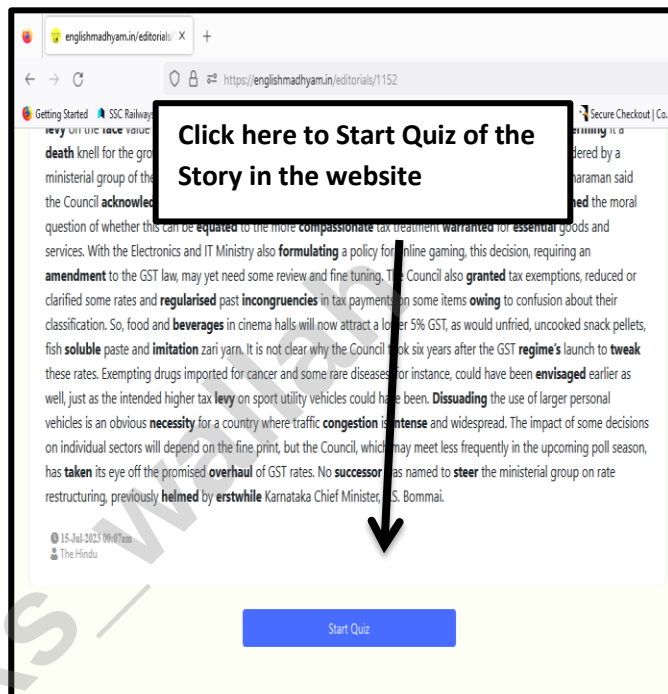
1. **Heaven** (noun) – paradise, sky, firmament, afterlife, celestial realm – स्वर्ग / आकाश
2. **Fond** (of) (adjective) – affectionate, loving, devoted, attached, tender – प्यार करने वाला / स्नेही
3. **Blood-red** (adjective) – crimson, scarlet, ruby-red, deep red, dark red – रक्तवर्ण / गहरा लाल
4. **Ruby** (noun) – gemstone, jewel, red stone, precious stone, corundum – माणिक्य / लाल रत्न
5. **Token** (noun) – symbol, sign, memento, keepsake, gesture – प्रतीक / स्मृति चिन्ह
6. **Silken bag** (noun) – silk pouch, soft sack, cloth bag, velvet bag, dainty packet – रेशमी थैली
7. **Beloved** (adjective) – dear, cherished, adored, treasured, favorite – प्रिय / अति प्रिय
8. **Auspicious** (adjective) – favorable, lucky, promising, propitious, fortunate – शुभ / मंगलकारी
9. **Pleased** (adjective) – happy, content, satisfied, glad, delighted – प्रसन्न / संतुष्ट
10. **Speed through** (phrasal verb) – rush, fly, race, zoom, dash – तेजी से गुजरना
11. **Aroma** (noun) – fragrance, scent, smell, perfume, odor – खुशबू
12. **Nostril** (noun) – nasal opening, nose hole, air passage, nasal cavity, nose channel – नथुना
13. **Feast** (noun) – banquet, celebration meal, spread, party, repast – दावत
14. **Resist** (verb) – oppose, withstand, defy, refuse, fight – रोकना
15. **Alight** (verb) – land, descend, settle, perch, touch down – बैठना
16. **Twig** (noun) – branchlet, stick, sprig, shoot, limb – टहनी
17. **Pass by** (phrasal verb) – go past, move along, walk by, stroll past, proceed – पास से गुजरना
18. **Knock down** (phrasal verb) – strike, hit, topple, bring down, push over – गिरा देना
19. **Swoon** (verb) – faint, collapse, pass out, fall unconscious, droop – बेहोश हो जाना
20. **Deftly** (adverb) – skillfully, swiftly, neatly, cleverly, efficiently – कुशलतापूर्वक
21. **Intend** (for) (verb) – aim, plan, mean, designate, target – के लिए होना

22. **Eagerly** (adverb) – excitedly, enthusiastically, impatiently, keenly, hungrily – उत्साहपूर्वक
23. **Reel** (verb) – stagger, sway, falter, lurch, wobble – लड़खड़ाना
24. **Furious** (adjective) – angry, enraged, mad, livid, wrathful – बहुत गुस्से में
25. **Scorching** (adjective) – burning, blazing, searing, boiling, blistering – झुलसाने वाला
26. **Gaze** (noun) – stare, look, glance, view, peep – टकटकी
27. **Pit** (noun) – hole, cavity, trench, crater, hollow – गड्ढा
28. **Dig out** (phrasal verb) – excavate, unearth, uncover, extract, dislodge – खोद निकालना
29. **Sapphire** (noun) – blue gemstone, jewel, corundum, precious stone, azure stone – नीलम

## Practice Exercise



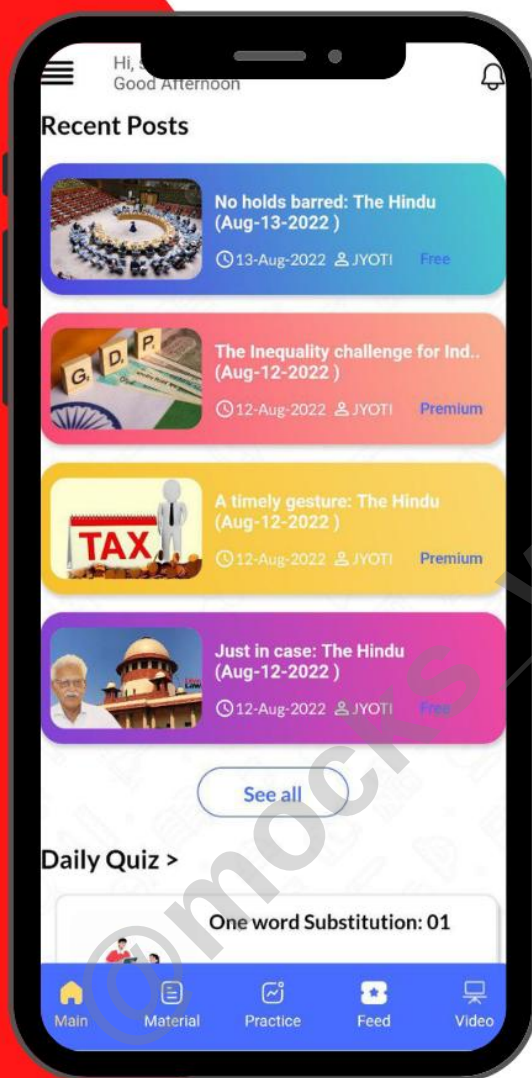
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